

1.2 Securing Web Hosting

Before choosing a hosting provider you have to determine what your needs are. For a start-up Web site, this might not be very clear, but you will have some idea about the kind of services you plan to offer your audience. There are a number of elements you need to be clear about before shopping around for a Web host. These include the type of site, the kind of database(s) required, special software such as chat, bulletin boards and shopping carts, the average number of visitors you expect, the number of e-mail users who will use your domain address, and the server side technology used for your site.

Each of these elements will determine your choice of Web host. The first choice you have to make is whether your Web site will sit on a shared server or a dedicated box. A shared server, as the name indicates, is a single physical server that will be hosting tens or even hundreds of other Web sites alongside yours. On the other hand, on a dedicated server, the entire machine is allocated to your Web site. An extension of the dedicated server is co-location. Unlike dedicated servers, a co-located server is owned by you. The Web hosting provider will provide a pipe to the Internet and your server will be connected to the Web.

There are advantages and disadvantages with each of these options. Let's take a look at each.

1.2.1 Shared Hosting

The main attraction associated with shared hosting is cost. For a fraction of the cost of a complete server, you can have a fully-functional Web site up and running in no time. Most hosting providers provide online setup and configuration of your accounts. This should have you ready to upload your site files within 10 minutes of paying up. Competition is fierce in the shared hosting market, so hosting providers trip over themselves to offer you a smorgasbord of features hoping to attract you into signing up. Don't get overawed by the feature list. Many of these features will have fine